

Degenerative Myelopathy (DM)

What is it?

Degenerative myelopathy is a slowly progressive disease of the spinal cord, similar to ALS (Lou Gehrig's disease) in people. It begins in the mid-back portion of the spinal cord and spreads. The exact cause is unknown, but it is linked to a mutation in the **SOD1 gene**. **DM is not painful.**

Which dogs get DM?

Older medium to large breed dogs, usually over 8 years (average 9). Highest risk: **German Shepherds** and **Boxers**. Also: Pembroke and Cardigan Welsh Corgis, Siberian Husky, Poodles, Chesapeake Bay Retriever, Rhodesian Ridgeback, Bernese Mountain Dog, Golden Retriever, Kerry Blue and Soft-Coated Wheaten Terriers, Wire Fox Terrier, American Eskimo Dog and Pug.

How it progresses

Stage	Timing (approx.)	Signs
1	First 6–12 months	Wobbly, weak back legs, often one side worse; "walking funny"
2	Next 6–12 months	Muscle loss, unable to move back legs or tail; leaking urine/stool
3	14–24 months	Front legs become weak
4	After ~36 months	All four legs paralyzed; trouble breathing and swallowing

Testing

A **DNA test** (cheek swab via OFA, ofa.org, or blood via University of Missouri) gives results in 1–4 weeks:

- **Normal** — no mutation
- **Carrier** — one copy; rarely develops DM
- **Affected / At risk** — two copies; may develop DM, but not all do and we cannot predict when

The DNA test alone cannot diagnose DM. Diagnosis is based on breed, age, signs and ruling out other spinal problems (such as disc disease) with **MRI** and spinal fluid testing. A definitive diagnosis is only possible by examining the spinal cord after death. Dogs testing Normal or Carrier that show signs need other causes investigated.

Treatment

There is **no cure**. What helps:

- **Daily gentle exercise** — maintains strength and may prolong mobility
- Physical rehabilitation; laser therapy and acupuncture may help
- No supplement has been proven to work
- Wheelchairs (carts), harnesses and good nursing care as mobility declines — see our *Nursing Care for Limited Mobility* handout

Prognosis

DM is progressive. Without support, most dogs lose use of the back legs within **6–12 months** of diagnosis. When the **front legs weaken**, humane euthanasia is often considered; we will help you assess quality of life.